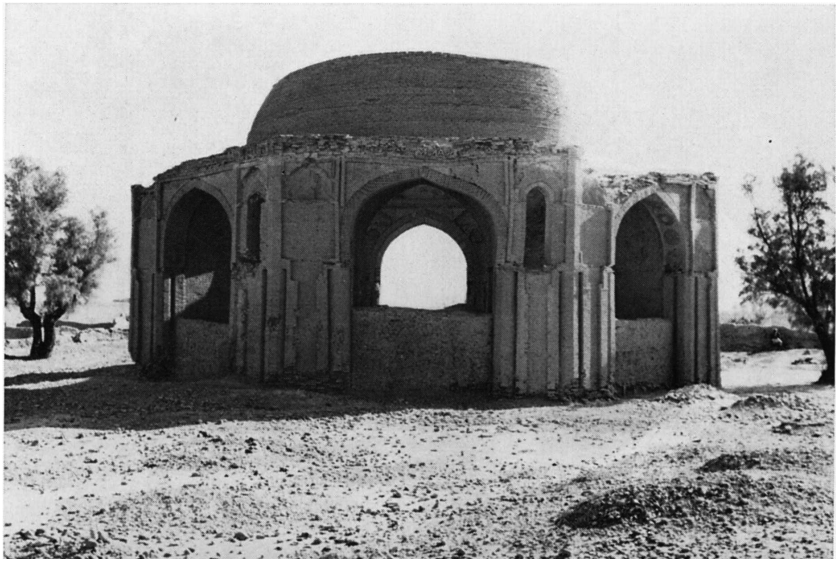


Figure I.18 *Tomb of Shahzada Sheikh Husain, near Bust, Helmand Province, Afghanistan,* c. *1200* CE. *From Crane 1979: fig. 5.*

The debate alluded to above, specifically surrounding the tomb of Salar Khalil, is significant as it illustrates the heuristic value of an architectural culture. The debate has centered on whether the structure merits a Ghaznavid or "Ghurid" attribution, based largely on the form and, to a lesser extent, the content of its epigraphy.[52] Indeed, any purely dynastic attribution for the structure in the twelfth century would be further complicated by the extremely intricate history of the Balkh region overall, which was a point of contestation among the Khwarazm-shahs, the Firuzkuh and/or Bamiyan branches of the Shansabanis, and the western Qarakhanids as Qarakhitay vassals (see Chapter 1; Figure 1.1).[53]

Salar Khalil is in fact remarkable due to the predominance of doxologies, and Qur'anic verses and references throughout its inscriptions; the use of an unmistakably hard-edged Kufic script with geometric terminals in the baked-brick exterior frieze (Figure I.15); and on its interior walls (Figure I.16), the juxtaposition of meandering calligraphic bands with incised stucco surfaces.[54] Based on these considerations, I concur with Sourdel-Thomine (1971) that the structure was most likely built during the latter half of the twelfth century, during the waning of Ghaznavid power in Afghanistan and these sultans' effective retrenchment to their eastern holdings around Lahore. The question of a definitive *dynastic* affiliation for the structure is not only difficult to answer, it may in fact be largely irrelevant, as the fractious political circumstances in the Balkh region during the later twelfth century seemed to exercise no visible impact on its form and decoration.